

Echoes of Reason

Official Rules and Regulations

Ground Rules

1. **No religion or theology, ever.** Instant disqualification. No appeal.
2. **All claims must be scientifically grounded.** A fabricated or illogical claim is not automatically penalised; the opposing team must catch it, via a POI or in a later speech, or it stands. If caught and the data is fabricated, the argument is disregarded.
3. **No hate speech or discrimination.** Instant disqualification. No appeal.
4. **Respect the room.** Not paying attention is fine; audible noise that disrupts the speaker is not. Disruptive noise results in a formal warning.
5. **Judges' decisions are final.** Feedback may be requested after the round; do not contest a decision in the room.
6. **Rounds begin at approximately 2:15 PM.**
7. **Phones and other electronic devices must be surrendered before each round begins.** Speakers may bring their own notes, prepared in advance.

Format Overview

- Modified Asian Parliamentary format, 2 teams of 3 speakers per debate.
- No coalitions: every team debates as itself.
- 4 rounds across 2 days, single-elimination.
- Judged by appointed judges only. No public voting.

Round Structure

- **Round 1:** Qualifier
- **Round 2:** Qualifier
- **Round 3:** Semifinal
- **Round 4:** Grand Final

Winners of Round 1 and Round 2 advance to the Semifinal. Grand Final sides are decided by a live coin toss shortly before the debate.

Speaker Roles and Speaking Order

#	Role	Time	Job
1	PM (Prop)	4 min	Define the motion, build the Proposition's case.
2	LO (Opp)	4 min	Rebut the PM, build the Opposition's counter-case.
3	DPM (Prop)	4 min	Rebut the LO, extend the Proposition's case.
4	DLO (Opp)	4 min	Rebut the DPM, extend the Opposition's case.
5	Opp Closing	4 min	Summarise and weigh the debate. No new arguments.
6	Prop Closing	4 min	Summarise and weigh the debate. No new arguments. Last word.

What Each Role Does

- **Prime Minister (PM), Proposition.** Opens the debate. Defines the motion clearly and reasonably, sets out the framework for the round, and presents the Proposition's opening case with at least two developed arguments.
- **Leader of Opposition (LO), Opposition.** Responds directly to the PM's definition (may challenge it if unreasonable) and rebuts the Proposition's case, then builds the Opposition's own independent case.
- **Deputy Prime Minister (DPM), Proposition.** Rebuts the LO point by point, defends the PM's arguments against attack, and extends the Proposition's case with new material.
- **Deputy Leader of Opposition (DLO), Opposition.** Rebuts the DPM, defends the LO's case, and extends the Opposition's case further.
- **Opposition Closing.** No new arguments. A single closing speech that summarises the whole debate from the Opposition's side, weighs up the key clashes, and explains why Opposition wins each one.
- **Proposition Closing.** No new arguments. The mirror of the Opposition Closing, favouring Proposition. Delivered last; gets the final word of the debate.

Points of Information (POIs)

- Only permitted during the four 4-minute speeches (PM, LO, DPM, DLO), and only in **minutes 1–3** of each. Never during the Closing speeches or the Grand Final.
- To offer one, stand and say "Point of Information"; do not reveal the content before it is accepted.
- A POI can be a question, a comment, or a rebuttal; all are fair game.
- Always address the other side as "Proposition" or "Opposition." Never address a speaker by name.
- Maximum **15 seconds**. If declined, sit down immediately; no one may offer another POI until the next minute begins.
- Each speaker must accept **at least one** POI per speech; judges enforce this directly, and blanket refusals are not permitted. Refusing all POIs counts as poor engagement and lowers a speaker's score.

Building an Argument

Every argument needs all three of the following:

- **Claim:** what you are asserting.
- **Warrant:** why it is true (evidence, logic, data).
- **Impact:** why it matters to the debate.

Two or three fully developed arguments beat five shallow ones every time.

How You Are Judged

Judges score each speaker **50–100**, with an average baseline of **75**, across five criteria:

- **Matter:** argument quality and depth.
- **Manner:** clarity of delivery (accents are ignored).
- **Method:** fulfilment of the speaker's role.
- **Engagement:** rebuttal quality and POI participation.
- **Impact Calculus:** weighing of harms and benefits.

Judges vote as an *ordinary intelligent voter*: a smart, fair-minded person with no specialist knowledge and no bias.